

Track 2 Participant Brief

Urban Business Resilience & Insurance Innovation



What the Winning Team Gets

\$1,500

Cash Prize

Awarded to the winning team

Pilot

Real SMB Opportunity

Deploy your solution with an actual small business

Track Overview

Urban small businesses are essential to the economic vitality of cities, yet they face increasing challenges related to operational risk, safety, and insurance access. In dense urban environments, many viable businesses struggle to obtain insurance - not because they are inherently unsafe, but because risk information is incomplete, mitigation tools are underutilized, or insurers lack clear visibility into property and operational conditions.

This track invites you to design technology solutions that improve resilience, safety, and insurability for small businesses operating in urban environments - particularly in Northern California cities such as Oakland, San Francisco, and San Jose.

Track sponsored by [District Cover](#): District Cover is a commercial insurance MGA focused on expanding insurance access for small businesses operating in complex urban environments. Through our work with brokers, property owners, and business communities in cities like Oakland and across Northern California, we see firsthand the operational risks and insurance barriers many small businesses face. We believe this perspective can help frame meaningful problem statements for participants and encourage solutions that improve both business resilience and long-term insurability.

Your Challenge: Insurance Readiness for Small Businesses

Participants will develop solutions that tackle real barriers between small businesses and the coverage they need. Strong solutions will address one or more of the following areas:



Help Businesses Understand How They're Evaluated

- Build tools that translate insurer risk criteria into plain language that any business owner can act on.
- Surface the factors that raise or lower a business's risk profile so owners can make informed changes.



Generate an Insurance Readiness Score

- Create a scoring system based on business and property data that gives owners a clear picture of where they stand.
- Make the score actionable - not just a number, but a roadmap to improvement.



Help Businesses Assemble Underwriting-Ready Documentation

- Many businesses are denied not due to actual risk, but because they can't produce the right paperwork.
- Build tools that help owners gather, organize, and present documentation in the format insurers expect.



Identify Coverage Gaps Before Renewal

- Help businesses spot potential gaps in their current coverage before they become costly problems.
- Give owners a proactive view of what's missing or underinsured ahead of renewal season.



Translate Insurance Into Simple Guidance

- Insurance language is notoriously complex. Build tools that convert dense policy language and requirements into simple, actionable steps.
- Especially important for first-time or non-English-speaking business owners.

Example Solution Types

These are illustrative starting points — not an exhaustive list. The best solutions may combine multiple elements or take a direction we haven't anticipated.

Solution Type	What It Does
Insurance Readiness App	Walks a business owner through a self-assessment and outputs a readiness score with a prioritized action plan.
AI-Powered Renewal Assistant	Guides SMB owners through policy renewal prep — gathering documents, flagging gaps, and summarizing coverage options in plain language.
Risk Summary for Brokers	Generates a one-page risk profile formatted for insurance brokers, pulling from property and business data.
Insurability Score Platform	Aggregates data over time to produce a simple score that improves as the business takes risk-mitigation steps.